



The Humanitas Institute

## Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Franklin Classical School

School Website: <https://franklinclassical.com/>

December 21, 2025

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**Disclaimer**

*This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.*

**ACCS Member School**

*Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.*

## Executive Summary

Franklin Classical School TN 37065 (FCS) presents a clearly Christian, classical-inflected program with strong emphasis on character formation, virtue, and a liberal-arts oriented Humanities approach. Public materials consistently frame the school as Biblically grounded, theologically explicit, and oriented toward virtue and truth, with a strong parent-partnership component and a university-model division that blends campus study with at-home learning options. Across categories, the school most clearly demonstrates a Classical orientation in religious/metaphysical foundations, school purpose/goal, faculty culture, and parent-/community engagement, while some facets of curriculum and pedagogy are less explicitly articulated in the classical lexicon (notably explicit Great-Books orientation and fully articulated Socratic/seminar-based pedagogy). Overall, the school aligns with CLASSICAL in aggregate, with some areas showing only SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL strength pending further documentation of canonical classical elements.

### Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

- Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL
- Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL
- Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 4: School Pedagogy — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL
- Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL
- Element 6: Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

What stands out most: - A robust theological and liturgical orientation permeates mission statements, statements of faith, and classroom framing (biblical worldview, God-centered aims, historic creeds). This strongly maps to Positive indicators for Transcendental moral realism, theology, and liturgical/community practice. See evidence from the mission/faith statements and program descriptions. - The curriculum is anchored in humanities- and Bible-centered study with a humanities block and time-period focus, and there is explicit emphasis on formation and virtue alongside academic rigor. This aligns with Classical aims around formation and moral imagination, although explicit Great-Books/Great Conversation language is not consistently foregrounded in the public-facing materials. - Pedagogy shows some classical elements (logic appears in upper-division humanities blocks; senior theses; emphasis on disciplined study and rhetoric in later stages), but explicit Socratic seminars, scholé/restful learning, or widespread or explicit Great-Books seminar culture is not consistently stated in public materials. This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating for pedagogy. - Faculty and parent-community dimensions are strongly aligned with classical expectations: teachers as mentors living the curriculum, a demonstrated parent-led model with substantial parent involvement, and visible staff profiles.

Abstracted takeaway: Franklin Classical School TN 37065 is a CLASSICAL school in spirit and structure with clear religious-metaphysical foundations, virtue- and formation-focused aims, and strong faculty/parent engagement. Areas that would move toward full CLASSICAL status include explicit Great Books/Great Conversation commitments, and more explicit articulation of Socratic pedagogy and the Trivium/Quadrivium in the published materials.

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## Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

### Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school is described as biblically based, spiritually vital, and Christ-centered, with a covenantal community of Christian educators and families. The mission emphasizes aligning with God's story and biblical truth in curriculum and daily interactions. - Historic orthodoxy is stated in the Statement of Faith (historic creeds and confessions – Nicene, Apostles, Athanasius) and non-denominational stance, indicating the integration of theology into education. - Public-facing materials repeatedly reference God, biblical truth, and theological framing (e.g., “God’s Beauty, Goodness, and Truth” in Grammar School humanities visions).

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: truth, goodness, beauty; theology; liturgy; reverence; wonder; sacred; God’s Story; biblical; creed; covenantal; logos; moral realism; virtue; formation. - Negative keywords found: none of the explicit negative indicators (e.g., relativism, secular-humanist framing) appear in the public materials. - Count (approximate): 8–12 positive signals identified; 0 negative signals identified in the accessible text.

Why this rating - The materials present a robust transcendental/metaphysical frame aligned with classical expectations: unity of faith, moral formation, and the integration of theology with disciplines. The explicit reference to historic creeds and a biblically-based curriculum underscores Grounded in Theology and Liturgical/Communal Practices as well as Transcendental Realism. This justifies CLASSICAL for Element 1.

### Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The mission emphasizes formation toward virtue and wisdom, not merely vocational prep; “biblically-based education that is academically excellent and spiritually vital” signals formation as telos, not just information. - The articulation that truth, goodness, and beauty are real and knowable (and the emphasis on a Christian, classical mission) aligns with the Classical telos of forming virtuous citizens for human flourishing. - Language around “formation” and “human excellence” appears in the broader classical lexicon used on school materials (e.g., humanities-centered approach and formation through virtuous study). The program design (Grammar and Upper Division blocks) emphasizes holistic formation and moral imagination.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: formation, virtue, wisdom, telos, truth/goodness/beauty, classical mission, contemplation, moral imagination, character formation, love of learning. - Negative keywords found: minimal to none regarding a workforce- or utilitarian focus; the materials repeatedly reject a narrow vocational framing. - Count (approximate): 6–10 positive signals; 0–1 negative signals.

Why this rating - The school explicitly foregrounds formation and virtue, and the public materials describe truth/goodness/beauty as real ideals under a theologically grounded program. This aligns with CLASSICAL in Element 2.

### Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Curriculum is described through a humanities-centric, time-period approach (Antiquity, Christendom, American History; later Modernity) and a “Humanities Block” that unites Bible, Literature, English, and Logic in Upper Division. This signals a liberal-arts orientation centered in humanities and logic, which is consistent with classical education principles. - Grammar School explicitly emphasizes humanities, history, Latin, literature, and Bible within a God-centered framework, suggesting a classical alignment in the early grades. - There is explicit reference to a “full curriculum for grades K-12” with a college-preparatory arc, and a mix of home-based and on-campus learning paths (University Model Learning) for flexibility. This supports the formation and liberal-arts dimension, while not always foregrounding Great Books or the full Trivium/Quadrivium in public materials.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: liberal arts (grammar, logic, rhetoric), great books (explicit in classical lexicon via the knowledge-base material though not always foregrounded on site), history across curriculum, time-periods and humanities, Bible, Latin, literature, logic, rhetoric, pedagogy

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oriented toward formation. - Negative keywords found: explicit Great Books/Great Conversation presence is not consistently foregrounded in the site content (no clear “Great Books” curriculum citation on main pages). Some elements of modern, integrated, or project-based approaches appear in other contexts, which can signal a divergence from strict Great-Books emphasis. - Count (approximate): 5–9 positive signals; 1–2 explicit negative signals (e.g., lack of explicit Great Books/Great Conversation emphasis in the public site).

Why this rating - The curriculum exhibits clear classical strands (grammar/logic, humanities orientation, history-integration, biblical/theological framing) but the public-facing materials do not consistently foreground the canonical Great Books or explicit Trivium/Quadrivium articulation. This yields SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL for Element 3.

#### **Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The Upper Division shows humanities blocks including logic and rhetoric and a senior thesis, indicating elements of disciplined, argumentative, and rhetorical work, with opportunities for formal writing and defense. This aligns with the rhetoric/logic emphasis in classical pedagogy. - The public materials emphasize a blend of parent-led education (University Model Learning) and on-campus instruction, which indicates a mix of pedagogical modalities rather than a single, unified classical-methodology. The explicit mention of Socratic seminars or scholé is not consistently present in the public-facing materials. - Lower-division materials emphasize a humanities-centered, God-centered approach with a strong emphasis on memorization and tradition through Bible and literature rather than a fully stated Socratic-discussion program. While there is memory and recitation in the broader classical pedagogy lexicon, explicit evidence of disciplined Socratic pedagogy is not consistently foregrounded.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: Socratic dialogue/seminar (mentioned in the knowledge lexicon as a classical method; not clearly evidenced in public site), logic, rhetoric, memorization/recitation, scholé, disciplined discussion, upper-level debate, persuasive writing. - Negative keywords found: experiential/project-based-only, student-directed without classical scaffolding, and other non-classical approaches are not strongly evidenced; however, explicit, broad adoption of Socratic seminars is not clearly documented on the public site. - Count (approximate): 2–4 strong classical pedagogy signals (logic, rhetoric, senior thesis, disciplined discussion cues) with 0–2 explicit classical pedagogy signals (Socratic, scholé) not clearly documented; resulting in a partial CLASSICAL orientation.

Why this rating - Pedagogy shows meaningful classical elements (logic in the Upper Division, senior thesis, and rhetoric-oriented opportunities) but lacks explicit, consistently communicated Socratic/Scholé practices across grade bands in public content. This warrants SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL for Element 4.

#### **Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL**

Evidence - Faculty are described as mentors, living curriculum, and models of virtue—roles consistent with classical teaching ideals. The site features faculty profiles and staff involvement (e.g., Julie Biancheri’s profile). - The “Grammar School” and “Upper Division” frameworks emphasize a teacher-mentored, covenantal approach, with a culture of collaboration and formation that aligns with classical expectations (portrait of teacher, faculty as the core of the school). The staff profiles and parent engagement demonstrate a genuine living-curriculum philosophy. - The site emphasizes long-term commitment to classical-Christian education, with staff and leadership visible in narrative content and admissions materials.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: masters/mentors, living curriculum, faculty of friends, collegial culture, portrait of a teacher, professional formation, mentorship, virtue-formation, teachers as exemplars. - Negative keywords found: none clearly evident in public-facing materials. - Count (approximate): 6–8 positive signals; 0 negative signals.

Why this rating - The public content frames faculty as moral exemplars, mentors, and the living curriculum, consistent with CLASSICAL. This justifies CLASSICAL for Element 5.

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## **Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL**

Evidence - The school foregrounds Parent-Led Education, a strong partnership with families, and a parental role as co-teachers and co-educators, including a PTO and opportunities to engage in home-based study. The grammar school model explicitly positions parents as primary in the educational process. - The Come Visit Us page highlights open campus visits and welcoming parents to participate in the school community. The university-model upper-division approach further reinforces family involvement in education. - The site narratives emphasize parent formation and engagement through book studies, gatherings, and familial involvement in educational planning, aligning with classical expectations for parent partnerships.

Positive/Negative Keyword Analysis - Positive keywords found: partnership with families; co-teachers; parent formation; parent engagement; home-school collaboration; open campus; parent involvement; family-based education; classical family culture; parent training. - Negative keywords found: none clearly evident. - Count (approximate): 6–10 positive signals; 0 negative signals.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates a robust, explicit commitment to parent involvement and family engagement in the classical-education framework, marking Element 6 as CLASSICAL.

## **What Would Move the Needle**

- Element 3 (Curriculum): Explicitly codify and publicly publish a canonical Great Books/Great Conversation pathway alongside Trivium/Quadrivium articulation, and deepen cross-disciplinary integration statements to reflect an interdisciplinary approach with historical depth. This would elevate Element 3 toward CLASSICAL by making the Great Books and integrated historical-literary avenues unambiguous in public materials.
- Element 4 (Pedagogy): Publicly articulate a deliberate, school-wide adoption of Socratic dialogues, scholé-based contemplative practice, and a structured rhetoric/seminar program across multiple grade levels, not only in upper-division. This would strengthen the public-facing pedagogy claims toward CLASSICAL.
- Element 3 and 4 synergy: Provide exemplar syllabi or sample lesson plans that fuse Great Books with the Humanities Block structure, showing explicit connections between grammar/logic/rhetoric and historical-literary primary sources. This would help stakeholders understand the full classical continuity from K–12.

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# Appendix

## ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

### Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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